CRISIS OF PRICES

IN WHAT PROMISES TO BE A CRUEL SUMMER, SCORCHING FUEL AND FOOD PRICES SINGE HOUSEHOLDS, AND HIGH INPUT COSTS WEIGH DOWN INDUSTRY. WHAT'S FUELLING THE INFLATIONARY FIRE AND WHAT CAN BE DONE TO DOUSE IT?

By **M.G. ARUN & SHWWETA PUNJ** / *Illustration by* NILANJAN DAS



For the past few months, Sreelekha Nambiar, a 38-year-old homemaker in Vashi, Navi Mumbai, has been wondering if seasonal shortages are driving up the prices of vegetables and groceries. The Rs 25,000 she sets aside for monthly household expenses has been getting her two-thirds of what she could buy a year ago. Vegetable prices are ruling at Rs 100-120 a kg in April compared to Rs 80-100 a year ago; cooking gas has become costlier by Rs 150, touching Rs 950 for a cylinder; and edible oil prices have jumped to Rs 200-220 a litre from Rs 80-100 a year ago. The Rs 22 a litre rise in petrol prices has made costlier her husband Satheesh's daily commute to the internet services firm where he works as a technician. There is also an EMI for their 1BHK flat, plus school fees for their daughter. "It's getting tougher to make ends meet," Nambiar says, with their income of around Rs 60,000 a month.